> the gate was reduced to a lattice of holes and collapsed to the ground, while the explosion filled the air with a storm of dust making everything invisible in all six directions. The Shah's troops rushed to storm the fort, and faced 300 ghazis, fighters for the faith, who drew their swords to defend their religion and three times drove back the British beyond the gates. The troops were forced to fall back and fired from a range of beyond 1,000 feet. But General Sale and the Commander-in-Chief rallied the men who entered the Fort and cut down the ghazis. The Bengal army once again charged and the Commander of the fortress Nawab Ghulam Haidar Khan [Dost Mohammad's son, who had escorted Burnes out of Kabul a year previously] was treacherously abandoned by his companions who hoped to save themselves and earn filthy English gold. They accepted English bribes, their faces blackened by treachery, and fled without fighting. The remaining ghazis fought till they drank the cup of martyrdom from the heavenly streams and were taken to the gardens of Paradise 'beneath which rivers flow', may God have mercy on their souls! Only after the death of the ghazis, did the English gain possession of the Ghazni Fort, and sound victory.[93]

As looting was raging in the lower wards of the fortress, a last doomed resistance was still continuing bravely at the very top. 'The Affghans fought gallantly with their swords, and succeeded in wounding several of our men even when themselves transfixed with a bayonet,' wrote George Lawrence.[94] His friend Neville Chamberlain was less impressed by the behaviour of the British troops. Atrocities were now taking place all around with 'soldiers breaking into the houses to look for plunder, and in this way many were killed . . . I shall not describe the cruelties and actions I saw that day as I am sure it would only disgust you with mankind; but I am happy to say very few women and children were killed, and that was a wonder, as when any person was heard moving in a room ten or twelve muskets were fired into it immediately, and thus many an innocent person was killed.'[95]

By dawn, the flight of the defenders had become a rout. 'Numbers of the enemy were seen dropping down from the ramparts with the aid of ropes,' remarked Thomas Gaisford.

> Some were shot while letting themselves down in this way while many that made good their escape were sabred in the field by the cavalry. After all the works were in our possession, bands of the Garrison who had shut themselves up in houses continued to fire upon the troops. Those who surrendered were given quarter but the standard bearer and others who killed many of our men long after the place was ours were shot on their being taken. After all had become quiet, a body breaking from a house endeavoured to cut their way out and wounded many men in the attempt . . .

The slaughter, Gaisford added, was 'dreadful'.